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The 4-Week Zone 2 Starter Plan

Find your zone. Build the habit. Start seeing real mitochondrial gains.

No coach, no treadmill, no excuses. Just your heart rate, 30 minutes, and four weeks.

What Zone 2 actually is (and isn't)

Zone 2 is the aerobic intensity where your mitochondria do their best work clearing lactate and burning fat. It's the slowest zone where you're still clearly exercising — a pace you could maintain for 90 minutes if your schedule allowed. If you're gasping, you're not in Zone 2. If you could read a book, you're not in Zone 2.

The catch: most beginners drift into Zone 3 within the first 10 minutes and never come back. Your HR monitor is the safeguard. Build the habit of slowing down. You are literally training the cellular machinery that the next 40 years of your life will depend on.

The three-method ladder for finding your Zone 2

Method 1 — Talk test (free). You can speak full sentences, but couldn't sing. Gets you 80% there on day one.

Method 2 — HR formula (80% accurate). Use the worksheet on page 3 of this PDF. Simple arithmetic, reasonable result.

Method 3 — Lactate test (gold standard, \$60-\$150 one-time). Optional upgrade. Pin-prick, at-home meter, treadmill stepped test.

Why four weeks, why 30 minutes

- **Four weeks** is long enough for your aerobic base to show measurable improvement (lower HR at same pace) but short enough that you'll actually finish.
- **30 minutes** is the minimum duration for mitochondrial adaptation to start. Under 20 and you're barely warming up the pathway.
- **3-4 sessions per week** beats 5-6 sessions for beginners. Recovery is where the adaptation happens.

Disclaimer: Consult a physician before starting any new exercise program, especially if you have cardiovascular conditions, take beta blockers (they suppress HR — formulas won't work), or have been sedentary for more than a year.

Find Your Zone 2 — Fill-In Worksheet

Do the math once. Commit the range to your watch as a zone alert. Live inside it.

Method 1 — Maffetone / "180 minus age" formula

Step	Formula	Your value
1. Your age	years	_____
2. Start with 180	180	180
3. Subtract your age	180 - age	_____
4. Subjective adjustment (choose one)	+0 if recovering from major illness / on meds -5 if out of shape or frequently injured +0 if training consistently 2 yrs+ +5 if competitive athlete, no health issues	_____
5. Upper Z2 bound	Result of step 3 +/- step 4	_____ bpm
6. Lower Z2 bound	Upper - 10	_____ bpm
7. MY ZONE 2 RANGE	Lower to Upper	_____ to _____ bpm

Method 2 — LTHR-based (if you know your LTHR)

Your Lactate Threshold Heart Rate (LTHR) is more accurate than the formula above if you've done a 30-min TT. Upper Z2 ≈ 70-75% of LTHR. Lower Z2 ≈ 60-65% of LTHR.

Step	Formula	Your value
1. Your LTHR (30-min TT avg HR)	bpm	_____
2. Upper Z2	LTHR × 0.75	_____
3. Lower Z2	LTHR × 0.65	_____
MY Z2 RANGE (LTHR method)		_____ to _____ bpm

Sanity-check your number

Upper Z2 for a healthy 40-year-old usually lands around 135-145 bpm.

Upper Z2 for a healthy 55-year-old usually lands around 125-135 bpm.

If your formula result is below 110 or above 160, re-read Method 1 step 4 — something is off.

If you take beta blockers, HR formulas won't work for you. Use RPE (6-7 out of 10) and the talk test instead.

The 4-Week Progressive Schedule

Modality is your choice: brisk walk, incline treadmill, stationary bike, rower, ruck (start light). Pick one and stick with it for all four weeks — consistency of signal matters more than variety while you're calibrating.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Weekly total
Week 1	Rest	30m Z2	Rest	30m Z2	Rest	30m Z2	Rest / optional walk	90 min
Week 2	Rest	40m Z2	Rest	40m Z2	Rest	40m Z2	Rest / optional walk	120 min
Week 3	Rest	40m Z2	40m Z2	40m Z2	Rest	40m Z2	Rest	160 min
Week 4	Rest	50m Z2	50m Z2	50m Z2	Rest	60m Z2 long	Rest	210 min

Session rules (follow these strictly)

- **Warm up 5 minutes** at walking pace (not counted in session time). Let HR come up gradually.
- If your HR climbs above Upper Z2, **slow down immediately**. Not next lap — now. Walk if you have to.
- The last 5 minutes should feel the same as the first 5. If you're dying, you went too hard from the start.
- **Cool down 3-5 minutes** at a slow walk. Let HR drop below 100 bpm before sitting.

If a session feels too easy — good

Don't speed up to "make it count." The feeling that you could've done more is the signature of a good Z2 session.

The gains you're chasing are cellular, not perceived. They show up as **lower HR at the same pace** by week 4.

Fill in after each session. Week 4 you'll look back at Week 1 and see the trend. That's the proof.

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What "progress" looks like after 4 weeks

Same pace, lower HR. The headline win. Your aerobic base is literally stronger.

Faster HR recovery. HR drops below 100 bpm within 90 seconds of stopping (up from 3+ minutes).

Steadier resting HR. Morning HR 3-6 bpm lower than week 1.

Subjective gains. Sleep quality up. Energy steadier through afternoon. Stairs don't spike your HR the same way.

Weekly Check-In Prompts

One minute per week. Rate 1-10, jot one sentence.

Week 1 check-in

Energy this week (1-10): _____ — one sentence on why:

Sleep quality (1-10): _____ — any pattern you notice:

Motivation to train (1-10): _____ — when did it dip, when did it surge:

Hardest session this week and why:

One thing I'll change next week:

Week 2 check-in

Energy this week (1-10): _____ — one sentence on why:

Sleep quality (1-10): _____ — any pattern you notice:

Motivation to train (1-10): _____ — when did it dip, when did it surge:

Hardest session this week and why:

One thing I'll change next week:

Week 3 check-in

Energy this week (1-10): _____ — one sentence on why:

Sleep quality (1-10): _____ — any pattern you notice:

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Motivation to train (1-10): ____ — when did it dip, when did it surge:

Hardest session this week and why:

One thing I'll change next week:

Week 4 check-in

Energy this week (1-10): ____ — one sentence on why:

Sleep quality (1-10): ____ — any pattern you notice:

Motivation to train (1-10): ____ — when did it dip, when did it surge:

Hardest session this week and why:

One thing I'll change next week:

Graduate from this plan

Finished four weeks? Don't stop. The base you just built is the foundation for everything else — longevity, strength, VO2max work, endurance events. Your next move depends on what you want from here.

- **Extend:** make 3-4 x 60-minute Z2 sessions per week your new baseline. Keep it boring.
- **Add intensity:** one Z5 VO2max session per week (4 x 4 minutes hard with 3-min recovery). Polarized model.
- **Layer strength:** two full-body lifting sessions on Z2 off-days. Preserves muscle, protects joints.
- **Pick a modality stretch:** Rucking — same Z2, weighted. Low-impact joint win.

Zone 2 Training Log — on Etsy

Printable 12-week training log with HR zone chart, weekly summary rollup, and goal-setting prompts. The natural next step after you've filled in the log in this PDF.

Grab it:

Zone 2 Training for Beginners — the full book

Vital Edge Press. Kindle + Kindle Unlimited. Covers the full 6-month progression, polarized vs pyramidal programming, HR variability, fasted vs fed sessions, and hybrid Z2 + strength programming.

Natural companion titles (same audience)

Rucking for Beginners — same zone, weighted, for joint durability.

Cold Plunge Therapy for Beginners — same longevity stack.